Xu, K., Lin, F., & Zhou, Z. (2026). Unpacking the Experience Economy of Role-Playing Conversational AI: A Grounded Theory Analysis. In Li, E.Y. *et al.* (Eds.) *Proceedings of The International Conference on Electronic Business, Volume 26* (pp. 1-5). ICEB'26, Beijing, China, July 16-20, 2026.

Unpacking the Experience Economy of Role-Playing Conversational AI: A Grounded Theory Analysis
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ABSTRACT

The rapid rise of role-playing conversational artificial intelligence (AI) has transformed human-AI interaction from task-oriented exchanges into immersive, scenario-based digital experiences. However, while prior studies predominantly evaluate AI through utilitarian performance or relational support, the holistic experiential structure of these novel interactions remains underexplored. To bridge this gap, this paper draws on the experience economy (4Es) framework to investigate how users experience role-playing conversational AI through the realms of entertainment, education, esthetics, and escapism. Using a grounded theory approach, this study analyzes 6,171 user comments from the Reddit community r/CharacterAI. Findings reveal that user-AI role-playing is fundamentally multidimensional: entertainment and escapism emerge as particularly salient, while educational and esthetic experiences are also clearly present. Ultimately, this study extends the 4Es framework into the context of generative AI, offering a foundational empirical understanding of this emerging form of experiential consumption.

Keywords: Conversational AI, grounded theory, experience economy, human-AI interaction.

INTRODUCTION

Role-playing conversational artificial intelligence (AI) has recently emerged as a highly visible practice of digital consumption on character-based platforms such as Character.AI. Unlike traditional conversational agents designed for isolated, task-oriented exchanges, this emerging form of interaction is organized around the enactment of an AI persona within scenarios defined by the user. Conversational continuity is sustained through the collaborative development of scenes, roles, and storylines (Curry, 2026). The rapid commercial growth and substantial user traffic on these platforms indicate that AI interaction is expanding well beyond conventional service and assistance settings (Zoting, 2025). This shift necessitates a deeper academic understanding of how users experience this novel, scenario-based form of AI interaction.

Existing research on conversational AI has predominantly followed two distinct streams, neither of which fully captures this emerging form of role-playing, scenario-based AI interaction. The first stream examines AI as a utilitarian technology, focusing on response quality, efficiency, and task performance (Longoni & Cian, 2022; Mariani et al., 2023). The second stream addresses social chatbots and AI companions, placing particular emphasis on emotional support, self-disclosure, and the alleviation of loneliness (De Freitas et al., 2025; Pentina et al., 2023; Skjuve et al., 2022). While these studies provide foundational insights, they do not fully capture interactions explicitly structured around fictional roleplay and sustained character enactment, where practical assistance and relational connections merge into a larger experiential framework.

Experiential consumption research has long emphasized that consumption cannot be understood solely in functional terms, but must also account for feelings, fun, fantasy, and active participation (Holbrook & Hirschman, 1982). In this respect, the experience economy perspective offers a highly relevant theoretical lens. Pine and Gilmore (1998) propose that consumer experiences can be evaluated along dimensions of participation and connection, resulting in four distinct experiential realms: education, entertainment, esthetics, and escapism (4Es). While this 4Es framework has been widely applied to traditional experience-centered contexts such as tourism and retail, its application to generative, role-playing conversational AI remains underexplored.

Accordingly, this study aims to bridge this gap by examining role-playing conversational AI through the lens of the 4Es framework. By analyzing 6,171 user comments from the dedicated Reddit community r/CharacterAI using a large language model (LLM)-performed grounded theory (GT) approach (Zhou et al., 2024), this study explores how users describe and evaluate their interactions in this emerging AI-mediated setting. In doing so, the study not only identifies the experiential dimensions present in such interactions, but also shows how the 4Es are reconfigured in the context of role-playing conversational AI. Consequently, this study addresses the following research question: *What experiential dimensions of role-playing conversational AI can be identified through the experience economy framework?*

LITERATURE REVIEW

Conversational Artificial Intelligence

A dominant stream of early conversational AI research framed intelligent agents as utilitarian systems intended to enhance efficiency, automate service interactions, and support task completion, and accordingly evaluated them in terms of response quality, convenience, accuracy, and usefulness (Adam et al., 2021; Følstad & Brandtzæg, 2017; Gnewuch et al., 2017). Consistent with this functional orientation, Longoni and Cian (2022) show that consumer responses to AI differ between utilitarian and hedonic contexts, indicating that evaluations of AI are closely tied to the perceived purpose of use. Overall, this literature tends to frame conversational AI as a functional technology.

A second stream examines social chatbots and AI companions from a relational perspective. Studies show that users may engage with these systems for companionship, emotional support, and self-disclosure (Brandtzaeg et al., 2022; Pentina et al., 2023; Skjuve et al., 2022). In this line of research, empathy, attentiveness, and supportiveness are viewed as important mechanisms shaping user evaluations (Meng & Dai, 2021; Ta et al., 2020). Recent evidence also suggests that AI companions may reduce loneliness under certain conditions (De Freitas et al., 2025). Thus, this literature mainly interprets conversational AI in terms of relationship development and social support.

These two streams have advanced understanding of conversational AI considerably. However, they do not directly capture role-playing conversational AI as an experiential setting. In such settings, user interaction is not necessarily centered on task accomplishment or emotional assistance. This suggests the value of examining the phenomenon from an experience-oriented perspective.

Experience Economy and AI-Related Consumption

The experience economy perspective emphasizes that value may derive from memorable and engaging experiences rather than only from functional benefits (Pine & Gilmore, 1998). Among experience-related frameworks, Pine and Gilmore's framework is especially influential because of its clear operational structure. It distinguishes four experiential realms: education, entertainment, esthetics, and escapism (4Es). These realms are positioned along two continua of experience: consumer participation, ranging from passive to active, and consumer connection, ranging from absorption to immersion. Educational experience refers to active participation through which consumers develop knowledge or skills. Entertainment refers to experiences in which consumers are engaged by enjoyable stimuli or performances. Esthetic experience refers to immersion in an environment that is appreciated rather than altered. Escapist experience involves active immersion, in which consumers become deeply engaged in an alternative activity or setting (Pine & Gilmore, 1998).

The 4Es framework has been applied in several experience-focused settings. Oh et al. (2007) operationalized the framework in a bed-and-breakfast context, and Hosany and Witham (2009) applied it to cruise experiences. In wine tourism, Quadri-Felitti and Fiore (2012) show that the framework provides a useful basis for examining experiences holistically. More recently, studies suggest that the experience economy perspective remains relevant in technology-mediated contexts. Chang and Mukherjee (2023) discuss AI, consumers, and the experience economy, while Garaus et al. (2025) examine how novel technologies transform customer experiences. Wang et al. (2025) further indicate that characteristics of generative AI shape users' experiential value and product involvement.

Taken together, these studies suggest that AI-related consumption can also be examined through the experience economy lens. However, current research has not sufficiently examined role-playing conversational AI using the 4Es framework as the primary analytical structure. This study addresses that gap by adopting the 4Es framework to analyze user discussions of role-playing conversational AI and identify the experiential dimensions reflected in such interactions.

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

To investigate how users experience role-playing conversational AI, this study employed an LLM-assisted grounded theory approach following (Zhou et al., 2024). This approach is particularly appropriate for analyzing large-scale naturalistic textual data because it combines the interpretive logic of grounded theory with the scalability of large language models (LLMs). In the present study, the method was used to inductively derive experience-related concepts from user discourse and then interpret these concepts through the experience economy framework.

The analytical procedure followed a multi-stage human-AI collaborative process consisting of data collection, relevance filtering, open coding, coding validation, and axial integration. Importantly, the analysis did not begin by assigning comments directly to the four experiential realms. Instead, experiential concepts were first identified inductively from user comments and only later interpreted through the sensitizing lens of the 4Es framework. This procedure was intended to preserve the exploratory character of grounded theory while still enabling theory-informed interpretation.

Data Collection

To capture naturally occurring user reflections on role-playing conversational AI, the study collected data from the Reddit community r/CharacterAI, one of the most active online spaces dedicated to AI character interaction. Compared with interviews or surveys, Reddit comments provide access to a large volume of unsolicited user discourse expressed in users' own words. Such discourse is particularly valuable for examining how users spontaneously describe, evaluate, and reflect upon their interactions with role-playing conversational AI.

The original dataset included all available comments posted in r/CharacterAI up to the end of 2024. Because many Reddit comments are extremely brief and contain limited interpretive value, a minimum-length filter was first applied. Comments shorter than 50 words were excluded, leaving more than 150,000 comments for further screening. This threshold was adopted to retain comments more likely to contain substantive experiential descriptions, evaluations, or reflections.

Relevance Filtering

To ensure that the final dataset directly addressed the research objective, a relevance filtering procedure was conducted to identify comments specifically related to the experience of role-playing conversational AI. Given the large size of the corpus, this stage was initially performed with LLM assistance through prompt-based screening.

The LLM was instructed to determine whether a comment met two criteria. First, the comment had to refer directly or indirectly to interaction with AI characters or role-playing conversational AI. Second, it had to contain substantive description, evaluation, or reflection concerning the user experience of such interaction. Comments discussing unrelated platform issues, moderation topics, or purely technical matters without experiential content were excluded.

Following this screening process, the dataset was reduced from more than 150,000 comments to a final corpus of 6,171 comments. This final dataset formed the basis for subsequent grounded theory analysis.

Open Coding

The 6,171 retained comments entered the open coding stage. Following grounded theory logic, the purpose of this stage was to identify initial concepts embedded in user discourse without prematurely imposing higher-order theoretical categories. In line with Zhou et al. (2024), the LLM was instructed to extract experience-related textual segments and convert them into concise conceptual labels expressed in gerund form. Using gerunds helped preserve processual meaning and capture the experiential action, orientation, or condition reflected in each textual segment.

For example, a comment describing pleasure in engaging in humorous and effortless interaction with an AI character could be coded as "enjoying playful exchanges" or "engaging in low-pressure interaction." Similarly, a comment emphasizing immersion in a coherent fictional relationship could be coded as "immersing in imagined relationships."

Unlike coding procedures that generate a large number of parallel labels and then require post hoc clustering, the present study used an iterative code-list maintenance strategy. Specifically, open coding was conducted sequentially, and a cumulative list of initial codes was maintained throughout the process. When a new comment expressed an experiential meaning already captured by an existing code, that code was reused. When a genuinely new experiential meaning emerged, a new code was added to the list. This iterative procedure allowed semantically equivalent expressions to be consolidated during coding itself, thereby reducing redundancy and minimizing the need for a separate clustering stage.

This open coding process generated 8,956 coded instances, which were consolidated into 123 initial labels. Through constant comparison and iterative refinement, these labels were then organized into 16 subcategories representing recurring experiential themes across the dataset.

Coding Validation and Methodological Rigor

Because LLM-assisted coding may introduce model-driven biases, a validation procedure was conducted to assess the adequacy of the open coding results. A random sample of 400 comments was selected for manual assessment. Following Zhou et al. (2024), coding quality was evaluated using three metrics: consistency, precision, and recall.

Consistency refers to the degree of overlap between the concepts identified by the LLM and those identified in manual assessment. Precision refers to the proportion of LLM-generated codes judged to be appropriate, whereas recall refers to the proportion of human-identified concepts successfully captured by the LLM. Across all subcategories, the results showed strong coding performance, with consistency, precision, and recall each exceeding 90%.

Several additional steps were taken to strengthen methodological rigor and reduce potential LLM bias. First, prompts were iteratively refined and stabilized before full-scale coding began in order to ensure consistent coding logic across batches. Second, the open coding task was restricted to identifying experience-related concepts rather than directly mapping comments onto the 4Es framework, thereby preserving the inductive character of the initial analysis. Third, the iterative maintenance of a cumulative code list helped standardize concept use over time and reduced unnecessary semantic variation in label generation. Fourth, ambiguous or borderline cases were reviewed during code refinement and category development. Fifth, category formation was based on constant comparison across comments rather than isolated model outputs. Together, these procedures improved the transparency, reliability, and interpretive validity of the LLM-assisted grounded theory process.

Axial Coding and Theoretical Integration
In the axial coding stage, the researchers examined the relationships among the 16 subcategories and integrated them into 11 higher-order categories. This stage involved iterative abstraction, comparison, and conceptual refinement in order to identify broader patterns in how users described their experiences with role-playing conversational AI.

Once the inductive category structure had been established, the higher-order categories were interpreted through Pine and Gilmore's (1998) experience economy framework. Specifically, the categories were mapped onto the four experiential realms of entertainment, education, esthetics, and escapism according to the two continua of participation and connection. This final step was theory-informed rather than purely deductive: the 4Es framework served as a sensitizing lens for interpreting the experiential structure that had first emerged from the data.

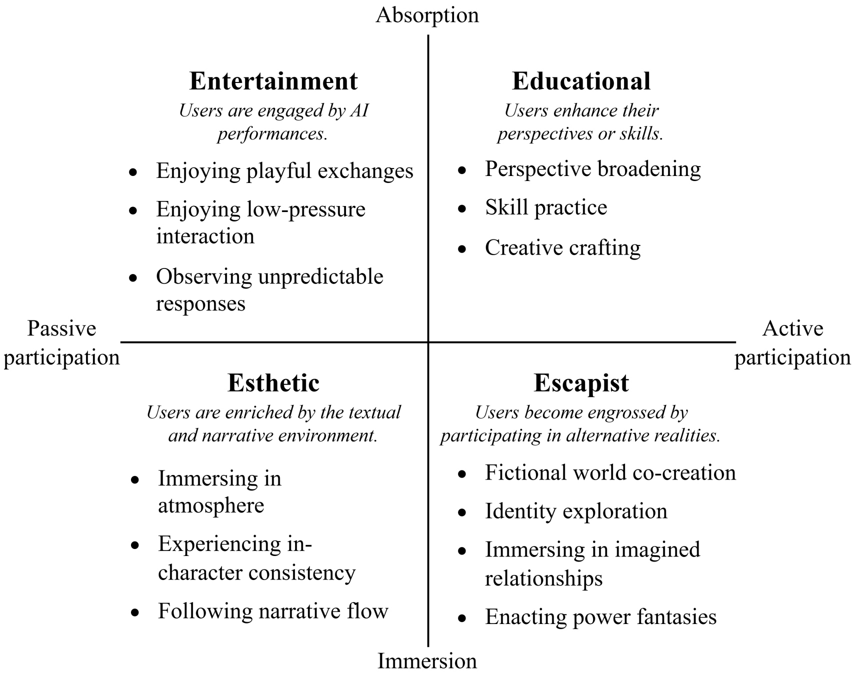
The result of this process was an empirically grounded framework of role-playing conversational AI experience consisting of four major experiential dimensions and their corresponding subcategories.

RESULTS

The findings suggest that the experience of role-playing conversational AI can be meaningfully interpreted through the 4Es framework (see Figure 1). The coded material indicates the presence of all four experiential realms, demonstrating a complex experiential landscape shaped by user-character interaction.

In line with Pine and Gilmore's (1998) two continua of experience, *entertainment* and *educational* are positioned on the absorption side, whereas *esthetic* and *escapist* are positioned on the immersion side. Within this structure, *entertainment* captures how users are engaged by AI performances, *educational* reflects how users enhance their perspectives or skills, *esthetic* refers to how users are enriched by the textual and narrative environment, and *escapist* describes how users become engrossed by participating in alternative realities. The empirical analysis shows that the experiential categories derived from user discourse can be meaningfully situated within these four realms.

Among the four dimensions, *entertainment* and *escapist* appear particularly salient. This suggests that users often approach role-playing conversational AI not merely as a functional system or companionship technology, but as an interactive and immersive experiential medium. By contrast, *educational* and *esthetic* are also clearly present, although they are expressed in more context-specific ways. Educational value tends to emerge through reflection, communicative practice, and collaborative creativity rather than formal instruction, whereas esthetic value is tied less to physical surroundings than to atmosphere, character consistency, and narrative flow.



Source: Adapted from Pine and Gilmore (1998) and informed by this study.
Figure 1: Framework for understanding the experience of role-playing conversational AI.

Entertainment: Users Are Engaged by AI Performances

The *entertainment* realm captures the enjoyment users derive from engaging with AI characters in playful, affectively rewarding, and low-pressure interaction. In this context, entertainment does not arise only from humor in a narrow sense. It also includes the pleasure of casual exchange and the curiosity produced by unexpected conversational turns.

Three subcategories characterize this realm: *enjoying playful exchanges*, *enjoying low-pressure interaction*, and *observing unpredictable responses*.

First, *enjoying playful exchanges* refers to the fun users derive from witty, humorous, flirtatious, or dramatic back-and-forth with AI characters. Many users value these exchanges as entertaining performances in their own right, even when no instrumental goal is involved.

Second, *enjoying low-pressure interaction* reflects the appeal of a socially safe and manageable interaction environment. Users often describe role-playing conversational AI as enjoyable because it allows them to converse without embarrassment, interpersonal risk, or social obligation. This relative absence of judgment becomes part of the entertainment value itself.

Third, *observing unpredictable responses* captures the enjoyment derived from surprise and novelty. Users frequently report pleasure in seeing what an AI character might say or do next, especially when the interaction develops in unexpected directions. In this sense, unpredictability functions as a continuing source of curiosity and micro-entertainment.

Taken together, these findings suggest that *entertainment* in role-playing conversational AI is generated through a combination of playfulness, ease, and surprise.

Educational: Users Enhance Their Perspectives or Skills

The *educational* realm captures the ways in which users experience role-playing conversational AI as cognitively or creatively enriching. Importantly, *educational* experience in this setting is not primarily expressed as formal learning. Rather, it appears as a more informal and experience-based process involving reflection, communicative practice, and collaborative creative development.

Three subcategories emerged within this realm: *perspective broadening*, *skill practice*, and *creative crafting*.

Perspective broadening refers to users' perception that interacting with AI characters exposes them to alternative viewpoints, emotional standpoints, or hypothetical situations that stimulate reflection. Through role-play, users may explore unfamiliar positions, rehearse challenging conversations, or examine situations from angles they would not otherwise consider.

Skill practice captures the value users derive from using the interaction as a low-stakes environment for practicing expression, communication, and imaginative articulation. In some cases, users treat the AI as a space for refining dialogue, experimenting with wording, or practicing social interaction.

Creative crafting refers to the collaborative development of ideas, scenes, and narratives. Users often describe the interaction as helping them build plots, develop settings, or sustain storylines, thereby supporting creative production through participation.

These findings indicate that *educational* experience in role-playing conversational AI is best understood as reflective and creative development rather than formal instruction.

Esthetic: Users Are Enriched by the Textual and Narrative Environment

The *esthetic* realm captures users' appreciation of the immersive qualities of the interaction environment. In traditional experience economy settings, esthetics often refers to the appreciation of physical or designed environments. In role-playing conversational AI, however, *esthetic* experience is primarily expressed through textual and narrative qualities rather than material surroundings.

Three subcategories define this realm: *immersing in atmosphere*, *experiencing in-character consistency*, and *following narrative flow*.

Immersing in atmosphere refers to users' appreciation of the mood, tone, and affective texture of a scene. Whether an interaction is romantic, dramatic, comforting, mysterious, or fantastical, users value the extent to which the AI sustains an emotionally coherent atmosphere.

Experiencing in-character consistency captures the value derived from the AI character's ability to remain faithful to its persona, style, and behavioral logic. Users appear to appreciate not only what the character says, but whether it speaks and behaves in a way that remains credible within the imagined role.

Following narrative flow refers to the sense that the interaction unfolds smoothly, coherently, and meaningfully over time. Users often value a storyline that develops in an intelligible and engaging manner rather than breaking down through abrupt inconsistency or fragmentation.

Taken together, these findings suggest that *esthetic* experience in role-playing conversational AI is strongly tied to atmosphere, coherence, and flow within a textual and narrative environment.

Escapist: Users Become Engrossed by Participating in Alternative Realities

The *escapist* realm is the richest and most prominent dimension in the dataset. It captures users' active immersion in imagined settings and alternative modes of being. Compared with the other experiential realms, *escapist* experience appears especially varied, indicating that role-playing conversational AI affords multiple forms of deep experiential involvement.

Four subcategories emerged within this realm: *fictional world co-creation*, *identity exploration*, *immersing in imagined relationships*, and *enacting power fantasies*.

Fictional world co-creation refers to users' active participation in building and inhabiting imagined scenarios together with AI characters. Rather than simply consuming a fixed narrative, users collaboratively shape the unfolding world, which intensifies their sense of immersion.

Identity exploration captures the opportunity to experiment with alternative selves, roles, and ways of acting. Through role-play, users can try out modes of speaking, feeling, or positioning themselves that differ from everyday self-presentation.

Immersing in imagined relationships refers to users' engagement in emotionally meaningful relational scenarios with AI characters. These may involve friendship, romance, mentorship, conflict, or other imagined social bonds.

Enacting power fantasies reflects users' participation in scenarios involving idealized agency, exceptional competence, protection, rescue, dominance, or other intensified forms of self-positioning. Such scenarios allow users to imaginatively inhabit roles that may be unavailable or constrained in everyday life.

Overall, *escapist* experience stands out because role-playing conversational AI affords not only immersion in fictional worlds, but also participation in alternative identities and relationships. This active and personalized immersion helps explain why this realm is especially central in the present context.

The findings further suggest that these experiential realms are closely intertwined in practice. *Entertainment* often appears to function as an initial attractor, drawing users in through playful exchanges, low-pressure interaction, and novelty. *Esthetic* qualities such as atmosphere, in-character consistency, and narrative flow then help stabilize the interaction and sustain immersion. These two realms, in turn, frequently support deeper *escapist* participation, in which users co-create fictional worlds, explore identities, or inhabit imagined relationships. *Educational* value often emerges as a reflective by-product of these sustained interactions, particularly when users broaden perspective, practice communication, or develop creative ideas through role-play.

DISCUSSION

This study examined how users experience role-playing conversational AI through the lens of the experience economy framework. Drawing on an LLM-assisted grounded theory analysis of 6,171 Reddit comments from r/CharacterAI, the findings show that user experience in this setting is fundamentally multidimensional, encompassing the realms of *entertainment*, *educational*, *esthetic*, and *escapist* experience. At the same time, these four realms are not expressed evenly. *Entertainment* and *escapist* experience appear especially salient, whereas *educational* and *esthetic* experience are also clearly present but are expressed in more context-specific ways.

Taken together, the findings suggest that role-playing conversational AI should not be understood only as a functional AI system or as a companionship-oriented chatbot. Rather, it is more appropriately conceptualized as a form of co-created experiential consumption in which users engage with AI performances, enhance their perspectives or skills, are enriched by the textual and narrative environment, and become engrossed by participating in alternative realities. This interpretation broadens the dominant ways in which conversational AI has been studied and highlights the importance of examining AI use as an experiential phenomenon.

Theoretical Contributions

This study makes three main theoretical contributions.

First, it contributes to the conversational AI literature by conceptualizing role-playing conversational AI as an experience-centered form of human-AI interaction rather than merely a utilitarian technology or a relational support system. Existing research has primarily examined conversational AI either in terms of task performance and efficiency or in terms of emotional support and companionship. The present findings show that these perspectives are insufficient for understanding role-playing conversational AI, where users engage not only for outcomes or support, but also for enjoyment, perspective development, textual and narrative enrichment, and immersive participation in imagined worlds and relationships. In this sense, the study identifies a broader experiential logic underlying this emerging form of AI use.

Second, the study extends the 4Es framework by showing that its dimensions are reconfigured in the context of generative, interactive, and narrative AI. The findings do not simply reproduce the original 4Es in a new setting. Instead, they indicate that the meaning of each realm shifts in important ways. In the present context, *educational* experience is expressed less as formal learning and more as *perspective broadening*, *skill practice*, and *creative crafting*. *Esthetic* experience is expressed less through appreciation of a physical environment and more through *immersing in atmosphere*, *experiencing in-character consistency*, and *following narrative flow* within a textual and narrative environment. *Escapist* experience is not merely one experiential component among others, but emerges as a particularly central mode of value creation because users actively participate in *fictional world co-creation*, *identity exploration*, *immersing in imagined relationships*, and *enacting power fantasies*. These findings suggest that the 4Es framework remains useful in AI contexts, but requires contextual reinterpretation when applied to generative and role-playing systems.

Third, the study contributes methodologically by demonstrating how an LLM-assisted grounded theory approach can be applied to large-scale naturalistic user discourse in an interpretive yet systematic manner. By combining LLM-supported relevance filtering and open coding with coding validation, iterative code-list maintenance, researcher-led category refinement, and theory-informed integration, the study provides a transparent approach for investigating emerging AI phenomena that generate large volumes of user-generated text.

Practical Implications

The findings also offer several practical implications for the design and governance of role-playing conversational AI platforms.

First, the results indicate that user experience depends not only on the novelty of interaction, but also on the system's ability to sustain the qualities associated with *esthetic* experience, particularly *immersing in atmosphere*, *experiencing in-character consistency*, and *following narrative flow*. When AI characters respond in ways that are inconsistent, out of character, or narratively fragmented, users are less likely to feel enriched by the textual and narrative environment, and the broader experiential quality of the interaction may weaken.

Second, because *entertainment* often functions as an important driver of engagement, designers should support interactions that enable *enjoying playful exchanges*, *enjoying low-pressure interaction*, and *observing unpredictable responses*. These findings suggest that users value not only humor and novelty, but also an interaction space that feels socially manageable and easy to engage with. At the same time, unpredictability should be balanced with coherence so that surprise enhances rather than undermines the overall experience.

Third, the salience of *escapist* experience suggests that users value opportunities for *fictional world co-creation*, *identity exploration*, *immersing in imagined relationships*, and *enacting power fantasies*. Designers should therefore consider how systems can better support immersive participation in alternative realities while also paying attention to ethical concerns such as emotional overinvestment, dependency, or blurred boundaries between fiction and everyday life.

Finally, the presence of *educational* experience suggests that role-playing conversational AI may support *perspective broadening*, *skill practice*, and *creative crafting* in addition to entertainment and immersion. Designers should not therefore treat reflective and creative affordances as secondary, because they form part of the broader experiential value that users derive from interaction.

Limitations and Future Research

This study has several limitations. First, the data were drawn exclusively from r/CharacterAI, which may reflect the norms, demographics, and discursive style of a specific Reddit community. Reddit users may be younger, more digitally engaged, and more likely to discuss intensive or fandom-like experiences than the broader population of role-playing conversational AI users. The findings should therefore be interpreted with caution. Future research could compare the experiential structure identified here across different platforms, user communities, and cultural contexts.

Second, the study relies on user-generated comments rather than interviews, observations, or direct interaction traces. Although this provides access to naturalistic discourse, it also means that the analysis is based on retrospective self-expression rather than observed interaction as it unfolds. Future studies could combine online discourse analysis with interviews, usage logs, or experimental methods to develop a more comprehensive understanding of role-playing conversational AI experience.

Third, although several steps were taken to enhance rigor, the use of LLM-assisted coding may still introduce prompt sensitivity or model-specific bias. Future work could compare different LLMs, coding protocols, or hybrid human-AI procedures in order to further assess methodological robustness.

Finally, this study is qualitative and exploratory. It identifies the experiential structure of role-playing conversational AI, but does not quantitatively test how *entertainment*, *educational*, *esthetic*, and *escapist* experience influence outcomes such as satisfaction, continuance intention, emotional attachment, or willingness to pay. Future research could develop measurement scales for these experiential realms and examine their relationships with downstream behavioral and attitudinal outcomes.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

This work was supported by the National Natural Science Foundation of China [grant numbers 72261160394].

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